

Session 18: The Dry Land

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors portrayed the dry land as a disc surrounded by and resting on the waters. It is set up on pillars that God upholds by his power.
- The dry land often symbolizes salvation, most notably, in Genesis 1 and the Exodus narrative.

The Dry Land

Genesis 1:9-10 NASB

⁹ Then God said, “Let the waters below the heavens be gathered into one place, and let the dry ground appear”; and it was so. ¹⁰ And God called the dry ground land, and the gathering of the waters he called seas, and God saw that it was good.

This passage gives us a mental picture of the waters receding from a mound of dry land and gathering into waters around it. The following biblical phrases assume we are familiar with this picture.

The Ends/Edges of the Land

Psalms 19:1, 4 Instructor's Translation

¹ The heavens declare the glory of God, and the dome declares the work of his hands. ... ⁴ Their line has gone out through all the land and their utterance to **the edge of the world**.

Daniel 4:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ Now these were the visions in my mind as I lay on my bed: I was looking, and behold, there was a tree in the midst of the land and its height was great. ¹¹ The tree grew large and became strong, and its height reached to the sky, and it was visible to the end of all the land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See also [Isaiah 26:15](#); [Isaiah 41:9](#); [Jeremiah 16:19](#); [Psalm 19:4](#); [Psalm 48:10](#); [Psalm 65:5](#); [Psalm 67:7](#); [Job 28:24](#); [Job 37:3](#); [Job 38:13](#); [Daniel 4:11](#); [Acts 13:47](#)

The Four Corners of the Land and the Four Winds of the Heavens

Isaiah 11:12 NASB

And he will lift up a standard for the nations and assemble the banished ones of Israel, and will gather the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth.

See also [Ezekiel 7:2](#); [Zechariah 2:10](#); [Zechariah 6:5](#); [Revelation 7:1](#)

In this world picture, the land disc is suspended over the dark abysmal waters below.

Psalm 24:1-2 NASB

¹ The land is the LORD'S, and all it contains, the world, and those who dwell in it. ² For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers.

Psalm 136:5-6 NASB

⁵ [Give thanks] to him who made the heavens with skill, for his lovingkindness is everlasting;
⁶ to him who spread out the land above the waters, for his lovingkindness is everlasting.

Exodus 20:4 NASB

You shall not make for yourself an idol, or any likeness of what is in heaven above or on the land beneath or in the water under the earth.

The Waters Surrounding the Land Disc

Proverbs 8:27-30 NASB

²⁷ When he established the heavens, I [Wisdom] was there, when he inscribed a horizon on the face of the deep, ²⁸ when he made firm the skies above, when the springs of the deep became fixed, ²⁹ when he set for the sea its boundary so that the water would not transgress his command, when he marked out the foundations of the land; ³⁰ then I was beside him, as a master workman; and I was daily his delight, rejoicing always before him ...

Job 26:10-13 NASB

¹⁰ He has inscribed a circle/horizon on the surface of the waters at the boundary of light and darkness. ¹¹ The pillars of heaven tremble and are amazed at his rebuke. ¹² He quieted the sea with his power, and by his understanding he shattered Rahab. ¹³ By his breath the heavens are cleared; his hand has pierced the fleeing serpent.

Isaiah 40:21-22 NASB

²¹ Do you not know? Have you not heard? Has it not been declared to you from the beginning? Have you not understood the foundations of the earth? ²² It is he who sits above the circle of the earth, and its inhabitants are like grasshoppers, who stretches out the heavens like a curtain and spreads them out like a tent to dwell in.

These passages do not describe a sphere floating in space, like we might think of. Rather they are talking about the horizon line (Job 26) or the round disc of the land surrounded by waters (Prov. 8; Isa. 40).

In many psalms, the dry land of Genesis 1 is identified with God's provision of salvation from the waters of chaos.

Psalm 18:2-3 NASB

² The Lord is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge; my shield and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold. ³ I call upon the Lord, who is worthy to be praised, and I am saved from my enemies.

Psalm 89:8-11 NASB

⁸ O LORD God of hosts, who is like you, O mighty LORD? Your faithfulness also surrounds you. ⁹ You rule the swelling of the sea; when its waves rise, you still them. ¹⁰ You yourself crushed Rahab like one who is slain; you scattered your enemies with your mighty arm. ¹¹ The heavens are yours, the earth also is yours; the world and all it contains, you have founded them.

Psalm 104:1-9 retells the story of creation, flood, and re-creation from Genesis 1 and 6-8 by using the imagery of waters rising or receding from the land.

Psalm 104:1-9 NASB

¹ Bless the LORD, O my soul! O LORD my God, you are very great; you are clothed with splendor and majesty, ² covering yourself with light as with a cloak, stretching out heaven like a tent curtain. ³ He lays the beams of his upper chambers in the waters; he makes the clouds his chariot; he walks upon the wings of the wind; ⁴ he makes the winds his messengers, flaming fire his ministers. ⁵ He established the earth upon its foundations, so that it will not totter forever and ever. ⁶ You covered it with the deep as with a garment; the waters were standing above the mountains. ⁷ At your rebuke they fled, at the sound of your thunder they hurried away. ⁸ The mountains rose; the valleys sank down to the place which you established for them. ⁹ You set a boundary that they may not pass over, so that they will not return to cover the earth.

This language makes sense only within a flat Earth model. While we still use some of these phrases, we do so in a non-literal sense. This is not so for the biblical authors. See the following examples.

- [Matthew 4:8](#): Jesus is taken to a tall mountain and shown all the nations of the land.
- [Revelation 1:7](#): "Every eye will see him ..."

Reflection on the Dry Land

What thoughts or questions do you have about the biblical understanding of the dry land?

Exodus 14: The Exodus as an Act of New Creation

Exodus 14:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ Pharaoh took his chariot and took his people with him, ⁷ and he took 600 choice chariots and all the chariotry of Egypt ...

Exodus 14:13-14 Instructor's Translation

¹³ And Moses said to the people, "Don't be afraid! Stand here and see the salvation of Yahweh which he will accomplish for you today. For the Egyptians you see today, you will not see them anymore, ever. ¹⁴ Yahweh

will fight for you, but you, keep quiet.”

Exodus 14:16 Instructor's Translation

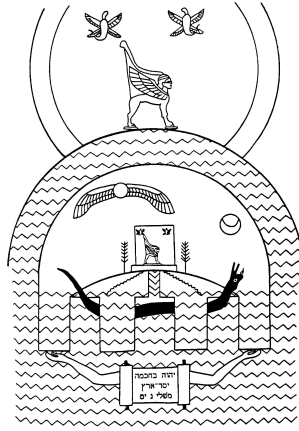
Moses, lift your staff and extend your hand over the sea and split (בקע) them, and let the sons of Israel go in the midst of the sea on dry land (יבשה).

Exodus 14:20-30 Instructor's Translation

²⁰ [God sets the pillar of cloud and fire between the camps of Egypt and Israel “all the night” (כל-הלילה).] ²¹ And Moses stretched his hand over the sea and Yahweh led away the sea by a strong east wind (רוח קדים עזה) all the night, and he turned the sea into dry ground (חרבה), and the waters were split (נבקע). ²² And the sons of Israel went into the midst of the sea on dry land (יבשה), and the waters were a wall for them, on their right and on their left. ²³ And Egypt chased and came after them, every horse of Pharaoh, his chariots and horsemen into the midst of the sea. ²⁴ And it came about at the morning watch (אשמרת הבקר) that Yahweh, in the pillar of fire and cloud, looked down at the camp of Egypt and confused the camp of Egypt. ... ²⁸ And the waters turned back (וישבו המים) and covered the chariots and horsemen ... in the sea, and there was not one of them remaining (שאר). ²⁹ But the sons of Israel walked on dry land (יבשה) ... ³⁰ And Yahweh saved Israel on that day.

“It should be evident that within the worldview of the ancient Near East, including the Hebrew Bible, their physical-technical and poetic-mythical statements and conceptions are not susceptible to consistent separation. To people in the ancient Near East, the empirical world, as manifestation and symbol, points beyond its superficial reality. A blurring occurs between the actual and the symbolic, and conversely between the symbolic and the actual. This openness of the everyday, earthly world to the spheres of divine life and bottomless, devastating lostness is probably the chief difference between ancient Near Eastern conception of the world and our own, which views the world as a virtually closed mechanical system. The principal error of conventional representations of the ANE view of the world lies in their profanity and lifelessness. In the biblical and ANE conception, the world is open and transparent to things above and beneath the earth. It is not a lifeless stage. The universe is thoroughly alive and, therefore, the more capable of sympathy with humans and of response to the rule of its creator, on whom both humanity and the universe directly depend. Certainly we have here more than a poetical personification of the cosmos, when it is invited to shout for joy!”

Keel, Othmar (1997). [*The Symbolism Of The Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book Of Psalms*](#). Eisenbrauns. 56.



Keel, Othmar (1997). "Figure 14" (p. 161). *Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

Reconstruction of the Israelite image of the world on the basis of biblical passages and iconographic elements from Palestine/Israel and its surroundings.

Reflection Question

How do the biblical authors talk about the dry land? In other words, what did it rest upon, what marked its edges, what shape was it in, and what held it up? And did it carry a positive, negative, or neutral connotation?